Interviewer guide: Years 3 and 4

This guide is reusable. Nothing is written on it: keep one in the room, in a folder or laminated. Ratings and notes for each student go on the **Interview sheet** (`forms/Interview_Sheet_Y3_Y4`).

About 8 minutes in Year 3 and 12 minutes in Year 4, 1:1. The interview is held **in English**, as a friendly chat. It has three jobs: to hear the child's spoken English, to get to know the child (likes, school, friends, **hopes for the future**), and to judge their **suitability** for the international programme. In Year 3 the sentence reading is done by the assessor, after the Early Reading Screen; in Year 4 the interview opens with the Graded Sentence Reading Screen (3 to 4 minutes; start Level 3; follow `shared/Sentence_Reading_Guide` and write the points on the Reading front sheet, `forms/Reading_Front_Sheet`).

How to ask. Sit beside the child. Have paper and crayons ready: some children talk more easily while drawing ("Draw something you love doing, and tell me about it"). Ask the main question first. If the child struggles, use the **easier** prompt (a yes or no, a choice, or pointing). If they answer easily, use the **stretch** prompt. Wait at least five seconds before rephrasing. Answers must be in English.

Pace of speech. Speak slowly and clearly: about 120 words a minute in Year 3 and about 130 in Year 4. Use the same pace for every candidate in the year group, and in Year 4 use it for the instructions and meaning questions of the sentence reading too. Do not rush: wait at least five seconds before rephrasing.

Safeguarding. Keep the door open or another adult present. If a child tells you something that worries you, do not promise to keep it secret; listen, write down their words, and pass it to the Designated Safeguarding Lead the same day.

1. Questions

Choose about two questions from each block. On the Interview sheet, write short notes under "Key things the student said": what they said, and how they said it.

Block	Main question	Easier	Stretch
Warm-up	Tell me about you.	What is your name? How old are you?	What makes you special?
	Who is in your family?	Do you have a brother or sister? A pet?	What do you like doing with your family?
School	Tell me about your school.	Do you like school?	What is the best thing about it?
	What is your favourite thing to learn? Why?	Do you like maths? Reading? Art?	What did you learn last week?
	What is hard for you at school? What do you do?	Is anything hard?	Who helps you?
	Do you read at home? Tell me about a book you like.	Do you like stories?	What happened in it?
Things I like	What do you like to do after school?	Do you like to play outside? Draw? Sport?	What are you best at?
	Do you have classes after school or at the weekend?	Do you go to classes on Saturday?	Do you like them?
Friends and feelings	Tell me about your friends.	Do you have a best friend? What is their name?	What do you play together?
	What makes you happy? What makes you sad?	Are you happy today?	What do you do when you are sad?
	How do you feel about a new school?	Happy, nervous, or both?	What would help you?
When I grow up	What do you want to be when you grow up?	Do you want to be a teacher? A doctor? Something else?	Why?

Block	Main question	Easier	Stretch
	What would you like to learn at our school?	Do you want to learn English? Sport? Music?	
Kindness	A child in your class is crying. What do you do?	Do you help them?	How can you help?
Questions for us	Do you want to ask me anything?		

2. Speaking band

Choose the band that fits best, for a child of this age, and tick it on the Interview sheet. Rate **listening in conversation** with the same letters. Pronunciation features of a speaker of Chinese do not lower the band if the child is easy to understand.

Band	What you hear
A New to English	No English yet, or a few single words ("yes", "cat"). Uses Chinese, pointing or silence. Understands very little without pictures or gesture.
B Early acquisition	Single words, short phrases and some simple sentences ("I like football"). Needs the easier prompts. Understands slow, simple questions with support.
C Developing competence	Answers in short sentences and can say a little more with prompting ("I like football because it is fun"). Errors are common; meaning is usually clear.
D Competent	Talks easily, joins ideas, tells a little story or explains, with occasional errors. Understands nearly everything said at a normal pace.
E Fluent	Speaks as a fluent English-speaking child of the same age would.

3. Suitability

Rate each strand on the Interview sheet: **1** Concern, **2** Some concern, **3** Good, **4** Strong. Write the evidence: a short quotation or what you saw.

Strand	What strong looks like at this age
Attitude to learning	Has a go, enjoys success, tries again after a mistake
Curiosity and engagement	Interested in the activities and pictures, asks questions
Social and emotional readiness	Separates from the parent and settles with a new adult, talks about friends, manages nerves
Independence	Follows two-step instructions, manages pencils and paper, can work alone for a few minutes
Kindness and conduct	Polite, shares, gives a kind answer to the kindness question
Readiness for learning in English	Happy to try English words, copies new words, not upset by not understanding

Boarding readiness (only if the child will board): independence with daily routines, sleep, homesickness. Rate it on the Interview sheet in the same way.

4. Anything to follow up

Tick any that apply on the Interview sheet, and add a note:

- Possible special educational need or disability (for example speech and language, attention, hearing, vision, fine motor skills, pencil grip)
- Wellbeing (for example very anxious, tired, very heavy after-school workload)
- Safeguarding (passed to the Designated Safeguarding Lead the same day)
- Medical or dietary

Receiving homeroom teacher (optional). If the likely homeroom teacher meets the child, they note first impressions and what the child would need in the first weeks (for example a buddy, picture cards for routines, a quiet space) on the Interview sheet.

To finish. On the Interview sheet, write your comment for the final mark sheet (strengths, concerns, support), and sign and date it.